Naughty or Nice

By Jonathan Mitchell and Seth Lind

UNIDENTIFIED PERSON: *(singing)* You better watch out. You better not cry. You better not pout. I'm telling you why.

NEWSCASTER: Deep inside the North Pole . . . past the tinsel, beyond the twinkling lights, is Santa's highly efficient, questionably ethical corporate headquarters. Forget sugarplums; this is surveillance footage, performance reviews, and elves with access cards. In a world where 30 seconds of bad behavior can earn you a lifetime supply of coal, one idealistic elf dares to ask the unthinkable: "Um . . . are we sure?" This is what happens when Christmas meets middle management. Sit back, stay off the naughty list, and enjoy . . .

INTRODUCTION

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NAUGHTY CHILD: I hate mashed potatoes. *(yelling)* You don't love me!

BELL: *(training)* OK. So, we're obviously seeing a class F temper tantrum.

SPARK: F is?

BELL: Food.

SPARK: Right - food. Food related.

NAUGHTY CHILD: *(yelling)* You don't tell me what to do!

BELL: So, go ahead and click naughty. She gets a lump of coal and, you know, she learns from that experience. *(Spark hesitates)* Click naughty. *(laughing)*

SPARK: Just like that? *(finally clicks the naughty button)*

BELL: Who do we have next?

SPARK: Michael Simmons . . . age 8. Tulsa, Oklahoma.

MICHAEL: Get out of here. Get out of here!

BELL: All right, so I'm going to give this one to you. Let's see how we do.

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MICHAEL: Stop being annoying! You've just been a little, annoying brat!

SPARK: He's mad at his sibling.

MICHAEL: I hate you!

BELL: *(shocked)* That's an ***I hate you***?! Hate's a word that you can't take back. Click naughty.

SPARK: But we have the tapes from the full year or more.

BELL: Yeah. If we looked at the tapes for the whole year, we'd be sitting here for a full year.

SPARK: So that's just naughty? *(frustrated)* Great. Michael Simmons - naughty.

BELL: Yeah. You got it. So you're all set?

SPARK: *(disillusioned)* Yeah.

UNAMED ELF: *(raising hand)* This one I was watching earlier today decided to feed all of his Ritalin to his Fox Terrier. His mom had to take him to the vet's office. The kid tore all the way through his sister's room. He took a leak in her toy chest.

BELL: Wow! That is layer upon layer.

UNAMED ELF: We'll see how he feels on the morning of the 25th. We'll see what's funny then.

SPARK: Do the kids actually know we're watching them all the time?

UNAMED ELF: It's in the song, right? *(singing)* He sees when you're sleeping. He knows when you're awake. He knows when you've been bad or good. *(speaking)* It's right there.

SPARK: What if we gave the parents more input. They are with these kids all the time. They can weigh in. I'm just surprised that the system...

BELL: *(dismissive)* They're not going to be objective -- especially when they're getting free presents from Santa.

UNAMED ELF: Don't overthink this, all right? You got yourself a nice, cushy job here. You want to sacrifice all that to go back to the toy factory? You want to shovel Rudolph's dung?

SPARK: *(backtracks quickly)* No. Definitely not. No. Glad to be here. *(steps out of scene to speak to the audience)* See, I don't want to complain about this job. But I'm looking at like 30 seconds of video of a kid, and then they're breathing down my neck to make an instant decision, like, this kid's naughty; this kid's nice. I really don't think this is how Santa would want it to run. *(as if hearing a call out from the audience)* Talk to Santa? *(loves this idea)*

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******* In Santa's office*******

SPARK: Hi. I put in for a meeting with Santa today. I'm Spark.

SANTA'S SECRETARY: Excellent. So what we're going to do is I'm going to alert your department as soon as there's an opening to meet with Santa. . . He's super duper busy with all the children's wish lists.

SANTA: *(exiting his office, shaking another person's hand)* Thanks for coming by.

COAL LOBBYIST: Remember the magic number is 2000 tons. If this works out, we'll **all** have a Merry Christmas.

SANTA: Ho, ho, ho. *(both exit)*

SPARK: Who was that with Santa?

SANTA'S SECRETARY: The most influential lobbyist for the coal industry and a very, ***very*** good friend of Santa's. . . Oh, good news. I see an opening on Santa's calendar in July.

SPARK: You know how many months away that is?

SANTA'S SECRETARY: If you want to get in here any earlier, you're going to have to sit on Santa's lap. *(laughs)* Just kidding.

******* In the sleigh area*******

MALL CREW LEADER: Mall crew on sleigh 6. I need all of my mall elves on the sleigh now.

SPARK: *(raises hand)* I'm on the mall crew -- I'm a trainee.

MALL CREW LEADER: There are no trainees on the mall crew. You ever been to a mall with kids who are drinking hot cocoa, eating candy, about to meet the most important man in the world?

SPARK: *(attempting a bribe)* Listen. I've got a candy cane I don't need. And it can be **your** candy cane if I just get on that sleigh.

MALL CREW LEADER: *(sucking on the candy cane)* You have no idea what you are in for!

******* In line for Santa at the mall*******

LITTLE GIRL: *(whispering)* Mommy, there's an elf in front of us.

MOM: Shh. Katie, that's not very nice.

SPARK: Zip it, kid.

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SANTA: Santa's got an empty lap here. Come on up here. You've been nice all year long?

SPARK: *(climbing on Santa's lap)* So Santa, this isn't about any present for me or anything. I actually work in the Naughty or Nice Division. And I am surprised and worried about how it works. We spend our whole day watching the surveillance videos of kids. Pushing the naughty or the nice button.

SANTA: Of course. Ho, ho, ho.

SPARK: Here's the thing. They are all nice **and** naughty. Every kid is **both**. Life is nuanced. Right? And we're reducing it to this yes or no thing.

SANTA: I see the problem. You are a very perceptive little elf. *(to staff)* Bring me my phone.

SPARK: You can fix this?

SANTA: Yes, I can. Merry Christmas. Ho, Ho, Ho *(ushers Spark away and talks into the phone)*

******** The next day at Human Resources *******

BELL: *(seriously)* Thank you for coming in. We got a call from Santa yesterday.

SPARK: That doesn't surprise me because I met with Santa yesterday. And it turns out that he is **not** pleased with how the naughty or nice system is being implemented.

BELL: *(continuing as if Spark hasn't spoken)* There are 50 million children in the United States alone. If we spend all of our time poring over the nuances for each child, we'll never get through our list. Tomorrow you report to toy factory 19. In **this** department, we need elves who can trust their instincts.

SPARK: Trust? I trusted that the system was fair, and now I've seen inside it, and it's just a bunch of flawed elves watching a bunch of flawed people deciding who is. . .

BELL: We can't let kids go without consequences. They'll grow up to be monsters. We are here to teach kids a lesson.

SPARK: *(indignantly)* I saw Santa meet with a coal lobbyist!

BELL: *(patiently)* Well, Spark, that's his job. Do you know how much cheaper a piece of coal is than a toy? It's just the economics of Christmas. *(no-nonsense)* Tomorrow, you to report to toy factory 19.

******* Toy Factory*******

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FACTORY ELF: *(training; holds onto two cables, pulling each as they chant)* Green, red, red, green, red, green, green . . . Spark, are you paying attention?

SPARK: What happens if I pull the wrong cable?

FACTORY ELF: Green cable, pre-assigned gifts. Red cable, coal. Just pull the right cable. That's the whole job.

SPARK: But if I accidentally were to pull the wrong one. . .

FACTORY ELF: A good kid would get a piece of coal.

SPARK: Or a bad kid gets a present?

FACTORY ELF: You're the last line between the gifts and the kids, OK?

SPARK: Right. I will **not** pull the wrong cable by accident. . .

******* Christmas morning at Michael's House*******

MICHAEL: Here's one for me! It says from Santa!

MICHAEL's MOM: *(shocked and surprised)* What?

MICHAEL: *(unwraps present excitedly)* Look, it's just what I wanted! And it's blue! Oh, my gosh!

MICHAEL'S MOM: *(aside to Dad)* You did it . . .

MICHAEL'S DAD: Why would I do it? I didn't! Honey, I didn't do it.

******* Back at the Toy Factory*******

SPARK: *(smiles and gives 2 thumbs up; singing as she pulls only the green cable)* You better watch out. You better not cry. You better not pout. I'm telling you why. Santa Claus is coming to town.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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